EDITOR'S DESK · 04

Barney wrote an editorial on introductions, then wrote its introduction using the method.

You can check his work line by line.

Very few people writing advice do this.

Three paragraphs. About a page and a half.

1 FIRST SENTENCE names the conversation you are joining. Then two or three sentences distilling its traditions and main findings, a distillation, not a literature review.

2 SECOND PARAGRAPH begins with one word, usually "However." It identifies one unresolved theoretical issue and explains why it matters.

3 THIRD PARAGRAPH begins "The purpose of this paper is...", one declarative sentence, then a brief preview of the answer and its implications.

THE VOCABULARY

Four terms doing the work in Barney's method

The conversation

Huff's metaphor, which Barney builds on: a literature is an ongoing exchange, and your first sentence must say which one you are joining.

Distillation

Compressing a literature's main traditions and findings into two or three sentences. A different skill from generating a bibliography, and the one on display.

The unresolved theoretical issue

The single problem the paper exists to settle. Not a gap, Barney is explicit that “not previously addressed” is an unacceptable reason.

The research question

One short declarative sentence beginning “The purpose of this paper is...” Papers with two or more are usually about none.

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One unacceptable reason why a theoretical issue is important is simply that it has not been addressed previously. There are literally thousands of issues associated with a particular theory that have not been addressed previously.

Barney (2018), Academy of Management Review, 43(3)

THREE MORE THINGS HE SAYS

Worth the reading on their own

1 “Papers that are about two or more research questions are usually about no research questions.”

2 About 1.5 manuscript pages, and, in a footnote: “There should be no cheating — no microfonts and no quarter-inch margins.”

3 Write a first draft, cut it by 20%, then cut it by 20% again. He applied this to the editorial itself.

4 “If this argument can be summarized in a single paragraph, it probably is not much of an argument.”

AN HONEST LIMIT

A formula this clean invites imitation of the surface.

You can write a paragraph that opens with “However” and still fail to say why the issue matters. A reviewer sees that immediately, because the form was never the point.

Barney says so himself: the approach “is not an algorithm.”

Treat it as a diagnostic. If the three paragraphs are hard to write, the difficulty is almost never in the writing.

SOURCES

Barney, J. B. (2018). Editor's comments: Positioning a theory paper for publication. Academy of Management Review, 43(3), 345–348.

Barney, J. B. (2018). Editor's comments: Theory contributions and the AMR review process. Academy of Management Review, 43(1), 1–4.

Suddaby, R. (2010). Editor's comments: Construct clarity in theories of management and organization. AMR, 35(3), 346–357.

The quickest test of the method: read the first three paragraphs of Barney's own editorial and label them. He built it to be checkable.

THE QUESTION

Write the first sentence of your second paragraph.

Does it begin with “However”, and does what follows say why the issue matters, or only that it exists?

Saturday: Weick on why discipline alone produces trivial theory. Barney is the sieve. Weick is what you have to put into it.

Post your sentence in the comments